

13-14 Performance Review

Manager Review

Jonathan Daniel Micklos

Performance Review: 04/01/2013 - 03/31/2014

Reviewer: Christoph Bichsel

Role: Manager

Status: Completed

Manager: Christoph Bichsel

Overall Performance Summary

Employee Summary:

This year presented opportunities to TPM various projects to delight our customers, reduce our operational costs, and prove myself as TPM II. I had transitioned from SDE to TPM at the beginning of 2013, making this my first full year as a TPM. The goals for this year included TPMing store development for Gen-6 announce, supporting store development for the AU, BR and MX Offline launches as KiSIT TPM, productizing custom detail pages, and migrating Kindle Device Detail Pages to UDP. In addition to my goals, I TPM'd the CN Promo Bundle project for both CN and JP.

Both the Gen-6 announce and the AU, BR and MX Offline launches completed. I tracked and reported on the different announcements we had for Gen-6 in the marketplaces we announced in. In addition to which, I helped solve getting product videos on the product detail pages for Gen-6. Very close to the initial US announce, it was noticed that identified that IE was no longer compatible with the Amazon Flash player. As a part of the replacement, I developed a process for uploading, encoding, hosting, and distributing (via CDN) videos through AWS. This process is still used by KiSIT and Kindle site merchandisers.

Productizing detail pages has been approached in three ways. In March/April 2013, I wrote a playbook for launching new devices in new marketplaces (<https://w.amazon.com/index.php/KiSIT/Secure/DeviceSalesPlaybook/NewMarketplaceLaunchPlaybook>). Secondly, we are migrating the kindle device detail pages to UDP and transitioning ownership of certain activities such as updating the SubNav/GNO. This work will reduce the overall cost for migrations. Thirdly, Kindle Device Sales is actively developing both configurator and sizzle site. Both of which will dramatically change the CX for Kindle customers, and by proxy, the launch process. I will list this as a goal for 2014.

Kindle Device Detail Pages have yet to be migrated to UDP. This is due mostly to continued slips in schedule for the Amazon-Wide UDP Project. Along the year, I have developed a few plans for how to migrate Kindle Device, Accessory, and Warranty detail pages to UDP. However, these plans have been frequently replaced and/or heavily modified due to continued changes in the Amazon-Wide UDP Project. This happened repeatedly throughout 2013. Examples include slips in support for Amabot, slips in support for Simple Stack as a retail platform, slips in support for DPX-PPD to be used outside of softlines in the US, and slips in support for the DPX-PPD Simple Stack adapter.

Currently, we are waiting for the Kindle Device, Accessory, and Warranty mobile/app detail pages to be migrated to UDP in late March by the DPX team. Once, complete, we will begin building and testing Kindle-specific mobile customer experiences for our detail pages. We will wait on UDP for desktop to mature further before recommending that KiSIT migrate the desktop Kindle Device detail

pages.

In addition to these goals, I TPM'd the CN Promo Bundle project for both JP and CN. I worked with the DiCE team in order to have them migrate CN e-books to Order Calc. I worked with the KLAW team in order to get changes made to Peter Pan for CN to support additional timing restrictions for apply promos. All of this I reported on during a weekly status update.

There are qualities from the TPM leveling guide that I have been tracking against. Specifically, for TPM II, I have been tracking the following:

"You manage multiple cross functional projects that span more than 10 teams at Amazon." – Gen-6 announce falls into this category as does UDP. For UDP, I have been working with KiDS, KLAW, KiSIT QA, KDS Design, KDS Product Management, KDS Site Merchants (multiple teams), DPX, Anywhere, Content Platform, Website Platform and Website Hosting,

"You define or review the systems-level technical design of your projects and balance near term business need with long term implications for Amazon." – I did this on a number of occasions with the UDP project. Additionally, I did this for supporting product videos for Gen-6 announce.

"Your primary responsibility is to drive projects to completion using cross functional project management best practices." – I drove CN Promo Bundles and reported on them both in a weekly team status update, as well as a weekly status update distributed to a CN Promo Bundle mailing list.

"You spend much of your time rationalizing technical requirements and business priorities in cross functional teams." – I did this many times with UDP. However, please see my areas of improvement – the priority/value that I placed was previously incorrectly weighed.

"You manage cross functional communication to ensure all business and technical stakeholder's needs are aligned." – I did this with the CN Promo Bundle and frequently with Gen-6.

Manager Summary:

Jonathan,

It has been a pleasure working with you the past six month and I am looking forward to the months ahead. You are a highly valued member of our organization and you made a huge impact for our customers and the business by launching stores and website feature to support new Kindle devices. You did a great job successfully achieved your commitments while transition from an SDE and catching up on functional PM skills. Your willingness to roll-up the sleeves to remove launch blocking issues such as the video issues made you fundamental to the success of our team. You have a lot of valuable skills and potential to further grow your career and our company. The ability to reflect, to be self-critical, and to solicit critical feedback from others enables you to consistently improve your skills and become more effective.

Identify Strengths

Employee Summary:

- Ownership/Dive Deep/Invent and Simplify – I am combing these as the example I wish to give for both is shared amongst the three. For the announcement of Gen-6 Kindle Devices, there were last minute issues with product videos. The Amazon-wide flash video player was no longer working on Internet Explorer (all versions). Because of this, a video player was needed. Chester Millisock was able to quickly build a temporary replacement for our video player in the image block with the AIRY Video Player. Because this player does not have a video encoding/hosting pipeline built for it, a custom solution was needed. I developed and documented a process for site merchandisers to upload and encode videos so that the AIRY Video Player could play them on Kindle Device Detail

Pages. Doing this included working with the AIRY Team to find a proper configuration for AWS Elastic Transcoder, working through the complexities of AWS IAM Permissions for setting up proper access control for site merchandisers, and setting up our S3 account to work with the AWS CloudFront CDN. This process is still used by site merchandisers and KiSIT for updating videos on new Kindle Device Detail Pages. Additionally, I tracked and reported on the launch of this video player on Kindle Device Detail Pages.

- Dive Deep – This year, I have repeatedly dived into the various dependencies that Kindle Device Sales has for UDP. This has happened repeatedly due to frequent changes in dependency timelines and milestones throughout the year. Two areas where this has been the most prevalent include what rendering platforms will be used for what clients (desktop/mobile/apps) and diving into getting support for Amabot campaigns on UDP.

- Think Big – During the vast majority of 2013, I have been pushing for a migration of Kindle Device Detail Pages to UDP as early adopters of the platform. In doing so, we would not only be able to help test/prove the platform for the rest of Amazon, but develop functionality that would be used on Kindle and other high-touch detail pages across Amazon. This approach puts Kindle Device Sales technology-forward for the rest of Amazon. Unfortunately, this approach has not been proven prudent due to development cost.

- Vocally Self Critical – This is something that I have listed in the past and will list again as it is very important to me. It is difficult to grow in one's career without being able to fess up to one's shortcomings. Additionally, it is difficult to improve as a team if members are not able to be vocally self critical about themselves and about the team. I am more than willing to be vocally self critical when appropriate.

Manager Summary:

Your assessment is consistent with the feedback of your peers. Continue building on your strengths and continue leveraging them to grow your scope and influence. Take ownership one step further by identifying and resolving systematic issues which drive people's behavior, even if they are outside your immediate scope to improve organizational efficiency. An example of this opportunity was the unclear ownership model between feature and launch TPMs which repeatedly caused tense situations.

Feedback from your peers:

He can dive deep and get to the bottom on any technical problem. He has an advanced knowledge of Amazon's systems and can grok solutions very quickly. He has great system knowledge related to RW (website architecture, widget interfaces, video encoding, amabot, etc...)

Jon also exemplified Bias for Action. He quickly gets to solutions, and dives right in. For example, during early sizzle site discussions he would jump up and whiteboard and begin to identify high level milestones based on very information.

Invent and Simplify is another strength. This is evident in his video encoding solution. He developed the documentation, and communicated and onboarding site merchants from all marketplaces to use the new cloudfront based encoding system

Jonathan is a super sharp guy who has much potential both in his current role, as well as anything he sets his mind to I suspect.

I've had the pleasure of working with him as both an SDE as well as a TPM and the same bar of excellence he sets for himself followed him from one role to the other.

He has a staggering amount of tribal knowledge which has been an enormous asset to me and is always quick to offer a suggestion about how something could be done or a better way to do something; and he's almost always right.

I am a big fan of Jonathan and I think with the proper guidance and mentorship he could grow into a

Sr. Leader at Amazon.

As a TPM, Jonathan seems to be very pro-active in helping me as a developer communicating to different teams and to product management. For example, during the peterpan project for China, Jonathan is always bridging communication gaps between devs and product management. When development is complete, he asked me for next steps so he can communicate clearly to product managers how they can use the product.

Identify Areas for Improvement

Employee Summary:

- Deliver Results – I have deliver results listed with regard to size/type of results. While I TPM'd projects such as CN Promo Bundle, Gen 6 Announce, and marketplace expansions, one that did not get delivered in 2013 was Kindle Device Detail Pages on UDP. Most of this was due to the fact that UDP was not ready as a platform for Kindle (and is still not). However, in retrospect, I want to get to this conclusion sooner. In the coming year, I want to be able to deliver on analysis/recommendations for potential projects sooner. Additionally, I want to be able to drive consensus across teams for projects of a UDP scale, and then track and launch them.
- Are Right, A Lot – In the past I have considered this a strength (from a technical position). However, as I have transitioned from SDE to TPM there have been two major changes with regard to judgment that I have needed to adapt to. As a TPM I have had to learn to transition the focus of judgment calls from predominantly handling technical decisions, to both technical and business ones. A good example of where this transition has occurred in the last year is during the UDP project. I have been pushing for Kindle migrating to UDP due to its lowered operational cost (once transitioned) and lowered cost for launching a custom Kindle Customer Experience for Kindle Device Detail Pages on mobile. However, in addition to the numerous slips in the UDP Amazon-wide launch schedule, failing to account for the business cost of the migration (early on) has made progressing with the project difficult. Another area in which judgment has changed for me is in judging what project to work on. As an SDE, the sprint's tasks make it very clear what is to be worked on. However, as a TPM, what one needs to work on is not as patently clear. It is incredibly important to have consensus as to what needs attention from one's management chain. Confusion in this regard can lead to project misstarts and wasted time. This has happened recently when I started to work on SingleFnSku without finishing the proposal on UDP first. This happened because there was a mismatch on prioritization in management that I should have sought to clarify. In the future I will.
- Hire and Develop The Best – In this past year, as a new TPM, the number of interviews I had done was lower than in previous years. Additionally, I have yet to have anyone who I've referred ultimately hired. I have started interviewing candidates for TPM positions. With regard to developing those at Amazon, I do not currently have a mentee. In the coming year, I wish to have a mentee and work closer with the developers on our team.

Manager Summary:

I do not consider "deliver results" as an area of improvement for you. UDP was challenging project with constantly changing scope and technical and organizational dependencies outside of your control. Ultimately, we all agreed that UPD is not our top priority. Your relentless effort to identify new options to unblock the project and your ability to recover from setbacks helped us to inform this decision.

Key for you career progression in the next year is to acquire the functional skills and level of influence necessary to progress to the senior level. Your example above "of being right a lot" and peer feedback below "on checking all the boxes", and developing a methodical approach to run projects are great examples of this. Much of this will come with experience by being exposed to these kinds of situations and applying your strength of being vocally self-critical to gain new skills and seeking out a good mentor.

Feedback from your peers:

Jonathan's biggest shortcoming I think is his interest to succeed and not taking the proper time to ensure that all of the boxes are checked before proceeding. I've seen several examples where he had to go back and fix something, be it in his code or a doc he's writing, in order for it to work.

Hopefully with some solid mentoring (which I know he is now getting) and growing as a leader that will improve.

While Jonathan was an effective communicator, I feel he can improve as a TPM by providing all parties in a project with a big picture. In the Peterpan project for China, I was very confused about order calc and how it was relevant to my project. Even though Jonathan was communicating clearly, I didn't have a good sense of the bigger picture and how other team's work play a part in the project I'm participating in. In my opinion, a great TPM can drive changes while keeping all parties aware of the overall picture and status.

Product managers for the peterpan China didn't seem to be too clear on their requirements, but Jonathan didn't play a huge part in helping business to come to a set of requirements. Instead, it was left to the engineers to work directly with product manager without the help of a TPM that knows the overall project.

The biggest area for improvement is in functional skills. He loses a great deal of effectiveness because he is too impassioned and too "busy." What I mean by that is he lacks the methodical, slow-and-steady, push-it-forward approach that is the hallmark of effective TPMs. He is naturally a sprinter, in a world of distance runners.

This is manifest in lack of Think Big - he is naturally a tactical, solutions oriented person and struggles with things that will take time and a lot of discussion and consensus building; he'd rather just do it. Which is fine if we're talking about small things, but "just doing it" doesn't work when a TPM needs to build a program that spans orgs (or even teams within an org.)

I think his Earn Trust suffers. Two things happen when he is impassioned 1) people dismiss him outright because they disregard what he is saying and 2) they tend to think lesser of him in the long-run, which becomes self-fulfilling. I trust him greatly and think he is honest and forthright. But I can see his working relationships with other TPMS (outside our team) are basically in shambles.

I'm also going to say that "Are right, a lot" is an issue for Jon. He is often right - alot, when dealing with small-scale, engineering problems. But, he is rarely right when it comes to the manner and means of getting something done for which he doesn't have direct control. His writing is often off, his struggles with communicating to the right audience, his tone and the forum/manner/cadence require a lot of coaching. I suppose this is functional skills, but this leadership principle dovetails with the earn trust issue - I don't think he has anywhere near the gravitas as a TPM, as he has for his technical chops. I think most of the org considers his TPM gig an ongoing experiment.

Ratings

Performance Rating: Achieves

Leadership Principles Rating: Solid Strength